Questions to Ask Dad, His Bank and a Professional About the Records a Medicaid Application May Call For

Fifteen questions, sorted by who can answer them, with room to write what they say.

Some of what you're looking for is in Dad's head, some is in a bank's records, and some depends on rules that only a professional who knows his state can speak to. This guide sorts the questions by who can answer them.

It doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. Nobody is applying for anything, so ask them as they are, when the moment suits, and write the answer under each one.

Dad

They're his papers. Ask a few at a time, when it's a good time for him, and take “I'd rather not say” as an answer.

1. Where do you keep things: the statements, the insurance papers, the deed? Which come in the mail, and which are online?

2. Besides the bank accounts, is there anything with paperwork of its own that I wouldn't think to ask about: an investment or retirement account, an insurance policy, a trust, an annuity?

3. Have there been any larger money events in recent years that would be easier to jot down now than to remember later: something sold, a gift, a large deposit or withdrawal?

4. If an application were ever needed, who would you want handling the paperwork, and who should know where everything is kept?

His bank, or his insurance company

Dad asks these himself, or you ask them together, with him there.

1. How do I get copies of my statements, on paper or online, and how far back do you keep them available?

2. For a particular deposit, withdrawal or transfer, can you give me a copy of the record that shows what it was?

3. Which policies do I have with you, and can you send me a current copy of each?

Your Medicaid planner

Someone who can explain the general application process and look over how your family keeps its records. These questions depend on rules that vary by state.

1. Which Medicaid program would likely apply to someone in Dad's situation, and where are applications submitted in his state?
2. What documents would we need to apply, and which of them should our file hold ahead of time?
3. How far back should we be keeping his statements?
4. Which documentation problems can delay an application, and what would you want a family to keep along the way?
5. What circumstances would indicate it is time to apply, and whom should we call when we see them?

An elder law attorney

Legal questions and legal documents belong to an attorney.

1. We have a question about a trust, a deed or a gift in Dad's records. Is that one for you, and what should we bring?

An applications specialist

The person an application is prepared with when it is time to apply. Nothing here needs asking today; keep these for then.

1. How do we complete the Medicaid application correctly, and what would you need from our file?
2. What happens after the application is submitted, and what should we keep track of?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, rank them, or say what any answer means for Medicaid. If an answer raises the idea of changing an account, a title or a gift, write that down as one more question for a professional. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You have your questions, and you know who each one goes to. The planning interview gives the answers somewhere to go: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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